Storylining & Communication

1. The storyline is the product

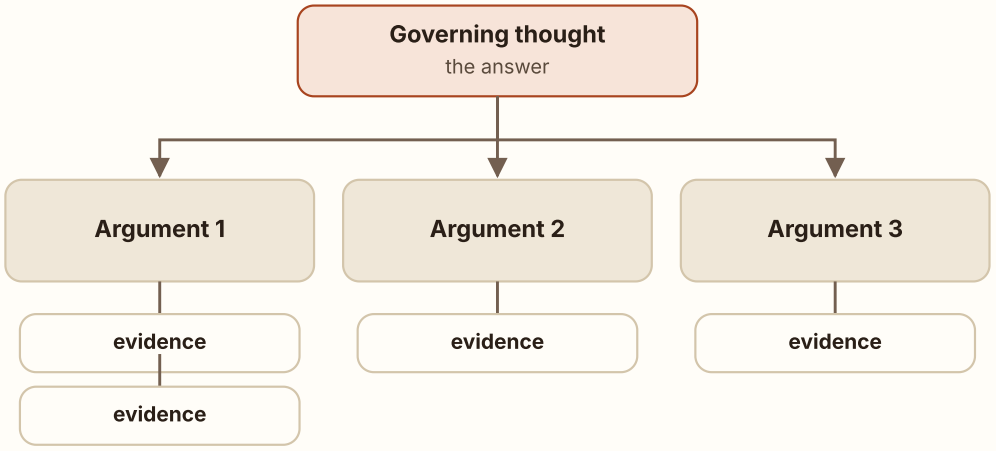
The analysis isn't the product; the **decision** is, and the storyline is how you get the client to make it.

- **SCR**: Situation (accepted context) → Complication (what changed or is at risk) → **Resolution** (your answer). Keep S and C short: their only job is to make the resolution feel necessary

2. The pyramid behind the deck

- **Governing thought**: one sentence that answers the key question
- **Key line**: 2 to 4 supporting arguments, each a full sentence
- **Support**: evidence under each argument
- **Vertical logic**: each level answers the 'why?' or 'how?' raised above it · **Horizontal logic**: arguments at one level are MECE and in a deliberate order

✎ DIAGRAM



Answer at the top; reasons; evidence underneath.

3. Executive summary and the dot-dash test

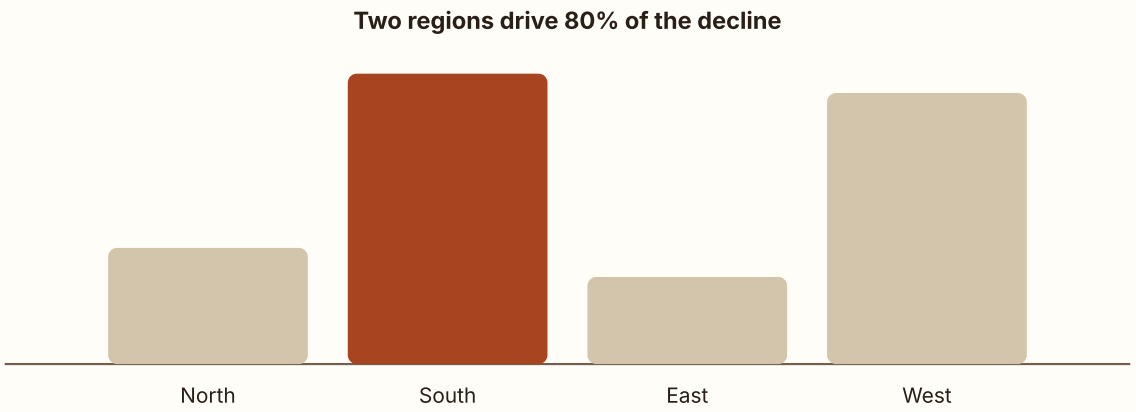
- **Executive summary**: one page that reads as the whole story: the answer, ~3 reasons with key numbers, and what you need from the audience
- **Dot-dash test**: write the storyline as bullets (dots) and sub-bullets (dashes) before any slides. If the dots alone don't convince, no chart design will

4. Slides that carry one message

- **One slide, one message, stated in the title**

- **Action title**: a full sentence stating the so-what. 'Revenue by region' is a label; 'Two regions drive 80% of the decline, both after the 2025 price change' is an action title
- Reading only the titles in order should tell the whole story
- Chart matches the message: bar (compare items), line (change over time), **waterfall** (how one number became another), stacked bar (parts of a whole)
- Highlight the data point the title talks about, grey the rest; label units, source and date; move detail to the appendix

✎ DIAGRAM

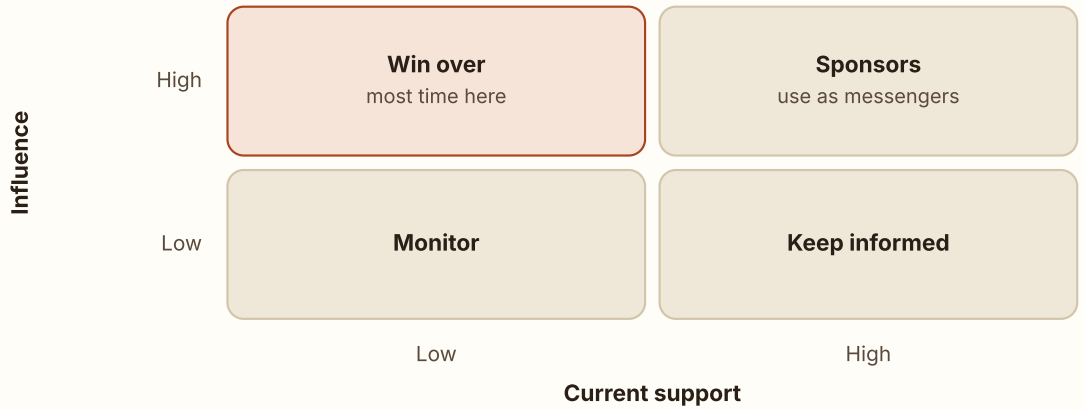


An action title plus one highlighted bar: the body proves the title.

5. Meetings, workshops and stakeholders

- **Stakeholder map**: influence × current support. High influence + low support needs the most time
- **Pre-wire**: walk key people through findings one-on-one before a group meeting
- **Workshops**: one objective, a pre-read, **diverge then converge**, capture decisions with owners and dates the same day
- **Pushback**: get curious first; disagreement on facts → resolve with data; disagreement on priorities → escalate to the decision owner
- Emails **answer-first**: 'We recommend option B; I need your approval by Thursday.'

✎ DIAGRAM



Spend your time where influence is high and support is low.

SAY IT

"Reading only the slide titles in order should tell the whole story, and every major finding is pre-wired before the steering committee."